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Lead Feature

Wars Of The Future

A World War IV soldier talks about his battlefield heroics

I know not with what weapons World War III will be fought, but World War IV will be fought with sticks and stones.

— Albert Einstein

I remember that quote well; I'm one of the reasons the great Einstein was proved wrong. But then, even Einstein couldn't have imagined how fast technology would invade our lives.

The quote was very popular during the Cold War, and even aided government-funded propaganda. Those were the days when most of us lived in fear, with images of mushroom clouds in our nightmares. The rich and paranoid built underground bunkers and stocked them with a year's supply of food. The rest of us would dart furtive glimpses at the sky at even the hint of a siren. When the Cold War finally ended, World War III began...

The third instalment is actually the only *real* World War. The soldiers are called "terrorists," and the battlefield is your backyard. It continues today; though governments have fought back and tried to minimise such events, you probably still read about the odd incident halfway across the globe, if not right in your city. To be honest, I cannot complain much about it, because WWII is what forced countries to go high-tech, get connected and start depending on technology—it's what lets me afford my luxurious life.

Who Am I?

I can't tell you my name for obvious reasons, but I can tell you that World War IV has begun, and I'm just one of thousands of soldiers fighting it. I've never held a real gun in my life, though I've fragged my fair share of enemies in my favourite FPS game. I'm certainly no James Bond either, and I have a fast-developing pot-belly—the kind beer-drinking couch potatoes proudly sport. I have a regular day job, which involves nothing more than sitting in front of a PC while I administer a small company's servers, so obviously, I bore easily. What I do have, however, is something my government is willing to pay a premium for, and it's the reason I have my moolah locked safely away in a Swiss bank vault. I drive a Maruti, but I can afford better. I live in an apartment—a true bachelor's pad—but no women ever visit. I guess they don't like the smell of rotting pizza, or my décor—if you can consider eight LCDs, four PCs and spaghetti tangles of wires "décor."

Chaitanya Surpur